

BRENDA ONG

Head of Communications · Crisis & Issues Management · Media Relations · Executive Communications

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SUMMARY

Communications leader with six years' experience running communications for a 15,000-person national institution, including two as its official spokesperson, across a 13-year career in law enforcement, INTERPOL and frontier technology. Owns the full remit: media relations, crisis and issues management, thought leadership, executive visibility, internal communications, and digital/social strategy. Approved 1,000+ news releases and led 25+ major press conferences annually; countered 20+ disinformation campaigns; managed a \$5M communications budget and a 28-person team; grew owned social to 1.3M+ followers. Briefed Reuters, AFP, Bloomberg and CNA. MIT Sloan MBA with hands-on AI governance and LLM evaluation work - fluent in translating complex technology into public language.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Communications Strategy · Media Relations · Organisation Spokesperson · Crisis & Issues Management · Reputation Management · Thought Leadership · Executive Visibility & Media Training · Internal & Employee Communications · Counter-Disinformation · Social & Digital Media Strategy · Communications Measurement & Analytics · Global / Cross-Cultural Communications · Public Affairs & Government Relations · AI Policy Translation · Budget & Agency Management · Team Leadership

COMMUNICATIONS LEADERSHIP HIGHLIGHTS

- Official spokesperson for a national institution of 15,000; communications strategy sustained a record 96% public trust rating.
- Led 25+ major press conferences annually, including fatal officer-involved shootings and national crisis incidents.
- Ran inter-government crisis communications cells countering 20+ disinformation and smear campaigns.
- Briefed international wire and broadcast media including Reuters, AFP, Bloomberg and CNA on national incidents.
- Managed a \$5M annual communications budget, a 28-person team and 1.3M+ owned social followers at 6% engagement.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

HOME TEAM SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY AGENCY (HTX), Singapore

Jul 2025 – Present

Principal Scientist, Disruptive Technologies Office (AI & Emerging-Technology Positioning and Executive Communications)

- Lead 8 executive workshops with 40+ senior leaders, converting emerging-AI strategy into 6 funded, communicable programmes.
- Deliver executive briefings translating a S\$65M+ AI, quantum and space portfolio into mission language for agency leadership.
- Prototyped an LLM behaviour-drift dashboard and public-sentiment forecasting tool for policy announcements.
- Convene industry, academic and government partners as ecosystem liaison, building the external narrative for emerging-tech adoption.

LYMEALERT, Boston, MA

Jun 2023 – Jul 2025

Co-Founder, Chief Operating Officer & Chief Marketing Officer (Brand, Marketing and External Communications)

- Owned brand, marketing and go-to-market communications for a pre-seed biotech, supporting US\$5M+ in startup financing.
- Built a stakeholder engagement framework spanning healthcare policymakers, industry bodies and government agencies.
- Defined pricing, positioning and commercial narrative, advancing 20+ partnership and distribution discussions.
- Cut manual reporting 66.7% (~10 hours/week) by automating leadership reporting across 5 workstreams.

SINGAPORE POLICE FORCE, Singapore

2013 – 2025

Assistant Director, Public Communications Division - Official Force Spokesperson (Feb 2021 – May 2023)

- Directed all external communications for a 15,000-officer national institution; communications programme sustained a record 96% public trust rating.
- Approved 1,000+ news releases, 1,600+ media responses and 90+ proactive features annually, holding message discipline at national scale.
- Led 25+ major press conferences a year as primary media liaison, fronting crisis incidents and flagship policy announcements.
- Led 9 proactive policy-communications campaigns explaining contested operational decisions - use of force, legislative change, response protocols, station relocations - to general audiences.
- Translated legally and technically complex decisions into accessible media briefs with policy, technical and community stakeholders, amplified 3X.
- Commanded inter-government crisis communications cells, countering 20+ coordinated disinformation and smear campaigns.
- Cut misinformation mean-time-to-detection over 50% to 3 hours using social-listening tooling and rules-based alerting.
- Grew owned social from baseline to 1.3M+ followers across five platforms; launched TikTok from zero to 300,000 in a year.
- Founded a 10-person New Media Unit publishing 5+ original content pieces weekly, creating a social-first capability from scratch.

- Media-trained and prepared the police C-suite for press conferences and town halls on a six-month leadership cadence.
- Founded a force-wide employee advocates programme, amplifying policy briefs 3X through officer-influencers and social networks.
- Programme-managed the Police Communications Masterplan, securing Ministry-wide buy-in for a new communications operating model.
- Owned internal communications for ~15,000 officers, sustaining above 75% employee engagement on internal pulse surveys.
- Managed and developed a 28-person communications team running a 24/7 operation at 100+ incidents daily and a 99% response SLA.
- Briefed and maintained working relationships with international wire and broadcast media - Reuters, AFP, Bloomberg and CNA - on national incidents.
- Ran media monitoring and measurement on Meltwater, Truescope and Echosec plus an in-house workflow, reporting sentiment and share of voice to leadership.
- Managed a \$5M annual communications budget, delivering the majority of reach through organic earned and owned channels.
- Authored 20+ forum-page letters and 100+ official statements for the Singapore Police Force, correcting the public record.

Head of Operations & Divisional Media Officer, Tanglin Police Division (Aug 2019 – Feb 2021)

- Served as divisional spokesperson on all operational issues, handling media queries and on-scene press for incidents and major security events across the Division.
- Commanded 30+ major security operations including Formula 1, aligning stakeholders to security aims, like media, tourism board, race promoter and private security.
- Managed S\$10M in annual resources for a 1,500-officer division, releasing 3,200 officer-hours through deployment redesign.

Deputy Team Leader, Crisis Negotiation Unit - concurrent (Jul 2017 – May 2023)

- Deployed as specialist negotiator on over 40 threat-to-life incidents, applying structured de-escalation and behavioural risk assessment.

Commanding Officer & Divisional Media Liaison, Bukit Panjang Neighbourhood Police Centre (Jan 2018 – Aug 2019)

- Acted as divisional media liaison and communications officer, fielding press queries and issuing statements on local incidents.
- Commanded 88 officers and cut five major offence categories 30% through data-led deployment planning.
- Co-authored an AI ethics policy paper feeding Singapore's national AI Governance Framework and Advisory Council.

Operations Officer, Future Operations Division (Jan 2015 – Jan 2018)

- Founded a futures and technology-policy unit, raising pilot-to-adoption conversion from 10% to 50% across six trials.
- Programme-managed a 10-year joint technology masterplan, cutting duplicative systems 42.9% across the force.

Investigation Officer, Central Police Division (Jun 2013 – Jun 2014)

- Solved 20+ investigations monthly while sustaining case solvability above 85%.

INTERPOL GENERAL SECRETARIAT, Lyon, France

Jun 2014 – Jan 2015

Executive, Strategic Planning Directorate

- Authored INTERPOL's Environmental Scan series forecasting law-enforcement challenges across 195 member countries.
- Produced executive mission briefs preparing INTERPOL's Secretary-General for international engagements.

SINGAPORE PRESS HOLDINGS, Singapore

Jan 2008 – Jun 2008

Journalist (Internship), The Straits Times - Money Desk

- Published 50+ articles on the financial news beat for Singapore's national daily newspaper.

SELECTED PROJECTS

Eight open research projects on AI misuse, safety evaluation, enforcement operations and crisis communications; four most relevant shown. All at brendaong.com and github.com/bibiong.

Crisis Comms War-Game — An adversarial multi-agent simulator for AI-safety incident communications, and the playbook it was built to test. Four incidents, four reactive adversary agents, three response postures, twelve reproducible runs.

- Found that stonewalling scores a perfect 1.00 on credibility while missing all four disclosure deadlines, and that a 13-minute delay bought 13 downstream contradictions — making the cost of silence measurable rather than asserted.

AI Misuse Threat Intelligence Atlas — Threat-intelligence corpus. Eight frontier-lab and platform threat reports coded into 55 individually cited operation records against a purpose-built kill chain and a verified MITRE ATLAS mapping.

- Coded influence operations, scam compounds and state-linked activity across eight publishers; found translation, not malware, to be the most widely converged capability, and quantified how much of the public record is an artefact of which company chose to publish.

APAC Regulatory Readiness — A maintained tracker of platform regulation across ten Asia-Pacific jurisdictions, plus a regulator response workflow, a measured AI toolkit and a readiness assessment framework. 17 instruments tracked.

- Found the models locate the obligation and miss the exemption: F1 of 0.79-0.96 reads as solved while carve-out recall on the same runs is 0.00-0.50, and 0 of 5 models surfaced threshold carve-outs — the failure mode that matters when briefing a regulator.

AI Incident After-Action Library — Twelve structured after-action reviews of public AI safety incidents — timeline, contributing factors, detection gap, corrective actions with owners — with schema validation and generated cross-library analysis.

- Measured disclosure posture across the library (median 0 days from detection to public disclosure) and showed that half of all publicly announced corrective actions cannot be verified by any outside party, including a regulator.

EDUCATION

MBA, Sloan Fellows Program - MIT Sloan School of Management	2024
<i>ASEAN Fellow · Specialisation in Business Analytics; coursework in AI & Machine Learning · GPA 4.9/5.0</i>	
MA, Security Studies - Georgetown University, School of Foreign Service	2012
<i>Outstanding Academic Achievement · Concentration: International Security · GPA 3.89/4.0</i>	
BA (Hons, First Class), Politics, Psychology & Sociology - University of Cambridge	2011
<i>Kerslake Scholar, Emmanuel College; Awarded Honorary MA in 2015</i>	
MTech in AI Systems (in progress) - National University of Singapore, ISS	2026 – present

CERTIFICATIONS, SKILLS & LANGUAGES

Certifications: Google Analytics Individual Qualification (2023) · Digital Marketing Bootcamp, Vertical Institute (2023) · Google Data Analytics Professional Certificate (2022) · Data Science Professional, DataCamp (2024) · AI Security, Lakera (2024) · AI Nanodegree, Heicoders Academy (2023) · Certified ScrumMaster (2023).

Tools & Skills: Meltwater, Truescope, Echosec (media monitoring and social listening) · Communications analytics and reporting · SQL, Python, R, Tableau, Power BI · AI-assisted workflows (LLMs, Claude Code, Codex) · Counter-disinformation frameworks · Crisis playbooks and escalation protocols.

Board & Service: Honorary Secretary (Board Member), POLWEL Cooperative Society (2022 – present). The Commendation Medal (COVID-19), Prime Minister’s Office, Singapore (2023).

Languages: English (native) · Mandarin Chinese (native) · French (basic)